

Section Three

Conduct Effective Interviews

CHAPTER 9

How to Conduct an Effective Interview

by Rebecca Knight

The virtual stack of résumés in your inbox is winnowed, and certain candidates have passed the initial screen. Next step: interviews. How should you use the relatively brief time to get to know—and assess—a near stranger? How many people at your firm should be involved? How can you tell if a candidate will be a good fit? And finally, should you really ask questions like: “What’s your greatest weakness?”

What the Experts Say

Hiring the right person for a job has become increasingly difficult, regardless of shifting labor market conditions. “Pipelines are depleted and more companies are competing for top talent,” says Claudio Fernández-Aráoz, a former partner and member of the executive committee of the global executive search firm Egon Zehnder and author of *It’s Not the How or the What but the Who: Succeed by Surrounding Yourself with the Best*. Applicants have more information about each company’s selection process than ever before. Career websites like Glassdoor have taken the “mystique and mystery” out of interviews, says John Sullivan, an HR expert, professor of management at San Francisco State University, and author of *1000 Ways to Recruit Top Talent*. If your organization’s interview process turns candidates off, “they will roll their eyes and find other opportunities,” even in a tough labor market, he warns. Your job is to assess candidates but also to convince the best ones to stay. Here’s how to make the interview process work for you—and for them.

Prepare your questions

Before you meet candidates, you need to figure out exactly what you’re looking for in a new hire so that you’re asking the right questions during the interview. Begin this process by “compiling a list of required attributes” for the position and asking “In which ways do we want to change our culture?” suggests Fernández-Aráoz. For inspiration and guidance, Sullivan recommends looking at your top performers. What do they have in common? What skills are missing? How are they resourceful? What did they accomplish prior to working at your organization? What roles did they hold? Those answers will help you create criteria and enable you to construct relevant questions.

Reduce stress

Candidates find job interviews stressful because of the many unknowns: *What will my interviewer be like? What kinds of questions will they ask? How can I squeeze this meeting into my workday?* And of course: *What should I wear?* But “when people are stressed, they do not perform as well,” says Sullivan. He recommends taking preemptive steps to lower the candidate’s cortisol levels. Tell people in advance

the topics you'd like to discuss so they can prepare. Be willing to meet the person at a time that's convenient to them. And explain your organization's dress code. Your goal is to "make them comfortable" so that you have a productive, professional conversation.

Involve (only a few) others

When making any big decision, it's important to seek counsel from others so invite a few trusted colleagues to help you interview. "Monarchy doesn't work. You want to have multiple checks" to make sure you hire the right person, Fernández-Aráoz explains. "But on the other hand, extreme democracy is also ineffective" and can result in a long-drawn-out process which increases the chances of rejecting or losing the right candidates for the wrong reasons. He recommends having three people interview the candidate: "the boss, the boss's boss, and a senior HR person or recruiter." Peer interviewers can also be "really important," Sullivan observes, because they give your team members a say in who gets the job. He adds, "They will take more ownership of the hire and have reasons to help that person succeed."

Assess potential

Budget 90 minutes for the first interview, says Fernández-Aráoz. That amount of time enables you to "really assess the person's competency and potential." Look for signs of the candidate's "curiosity, insight, engagement, and determination." Sullivan advises interviewers to "assume that the person will be promoted and that they will be a manager someday. The question then becomes not only 'Can this person do the job today?' but 'Can they do the job a year from now when the world has changed?'" Ask the candidate how they learn and for their thoughts on where your industry is going. "No one can predict the future, but you want someone who is thinking about it every day," he explains.

Ask for real solutions

Don't waste your breath with absurd questions like: *What are your weaknesses?* "You might as well say, 'Lie to me,'" says Sullivan. Instead try to discern how the candidate would handle real situations related to the job. Explain a problem your team struggles with and ask the candidate to walk you through how they would solve it. Or describe a process your company uses and ask the candidate to identify inefficiencies. Go back to your list of desired attributes, says Fernández-Aráoz. If you're looking for an executive who will need to influence a large number of people over whom they won't have formal power, ask: "Have you ever been in a situation where you had to persuade other people who were not your direct reports to do something? How did you do it? And what were the consequences?"

Consider "cultural fit," but don't obsess

Much has been made about the importance of "cultural fit" in successful hiring. And you should look for signs that "the candidate will be comfortable" at your organization, says Fernández-Aráoz. Think about your company's work environment and compare it to the candidate's orientation. Are they a long-term planner or a short-term thinker? Are they collaborative or do they prefer working independently? But, says Sullivan, your perception of a candidate's disposition isn't necessarily indicative of whether they can acclimate to a new culture. "People adapt," he says. "What you really want to know is: Can they adjust?"

Sell the job

If the meeting is going well and you believe that the candidate is worth wooing, spend time during the second half of the interview selling the role and the organization. "If you focus too much on selling at the beginning, it's hard to be objective," says Fernández-Aráoz. But once you're confident in the candidate, "tell the person why you think they are a good fit." Bear in mind that the interview is a mutual

screening process. “Make the process fun,” says Sullivan. Ask them if there’s anyone on the team they’d like to meet. The best people to sell the job are those who “live it,” he explains. “Peers give an honest picture of what the organization is like.”

Case Study: Provide Relevant, Real-Life Scenarios to Reveal How Candidates Think

The vast majority of hires at Four Kitchens, a web design firm in Austin, Texas, are through employee referrals. So when Todd Ross Nienkerk, the company’s cofounder and CEO, had an opening for an account manager, he had a hunch about who should get the job. “It was somebody who’d been a finalist for a position here years ago,” says Todd. (We’ll call her Deborah.) “We kept her in mind, and when this job opened, she was the first person we called.”

Even though Deborah was a favored candidate, she again went through the company’s three-step interview process. The first focused on skills. When Four Kitchens interviews designers or coders, it typically asks applicants to provide a portfolio of work. “We ask them to talk us through their process. We’re not grilling them, but we want to know how they think, and we want to see their personal communication style.” But for the account manager role, Todd took a slightly different tack. Before the interview, he and the company’s head of business development put together a job description and then came up with questions based on the relevant responsibilities. They started with questions like: *What are things you look for in a good client? What are red flags in a client relationship? How do you deal with stress?*

Then Todd presented Deborah with a series of redacted client emails that represented a cross-section of day-to-day communication: Some were standard requests for status updates; others involved serious contract disputes and pointed questions. “We said, ‘Pretend you work here. Talk us through how you’d handle this.’ It put her on the spot, but frankly, this is what the job entails.”

After a successful first round, Deborah moved on to the second phase, the team interview. In this instance, she met with a project manager, a designer, and two developers. “These are an opportunity for applicants to find out what it’s like to work here,” says Todd. “But the biggest reason we do it is to ensure that everyone is involved in the process and feels a sense of ownership over the hire.”

The final stage was the partner interview, during which Todd asked Deborah questions about career goals and the industry. “It was also an opportunity for her to ask us tough questions about where our company is headed,” he says.

Deborah got the job.

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CHAPTER 10

Evaluate a Candidate's Critical Thinking Skills

by Christopher Frank, Paul Magnone, and Oded Netzer

Hiring is one of the most challenging competencies to master, yet it is one of the most strategic and impactful managerial functions. A McKinsey study quantified that superior talent is up to eight times more productive, showing that the relationship between talent quality and business performance is dramatic.¹ Organizations seeking growth or simply survival during difficult times must successfully recruit A-list talent, thought leaders, and subject matter experts. This is often done under time constraints, as they must quickly fill a key position. Essentially, you are committing to a long-term relationship after a few very short dates.

Now let's consider the typical process of hiring talent. The primary tool we use to assess talent is a set of job interviews. The typical interview process is a Q&A format where some version of the common questions are asked of the candidate: *Tell us about your background. Why do you want to work for us? Share a challenge you faced at work and how you dealt with it. What are you most proud of? What impact have you had? Why are you the best person for the job? What is your greatest achievement? What are your weaknesses?*

While much has been said in favor and against the value of interviews themselves, the typical Q&A job interview process fails to assess one of the most important, if not *the* most important, skills you should be looking for from people you hire—critical thinking. Critical thinking is seeking information from various sources, assessing its credibility, and determining its relevance and veracity. Often classified as a higher-order skill, critical thinking is not a single skill but a collection of skills involving reasoning, constructing sound arguments, and identifying a situation's flaws, biases, logic, or inconsistencies. Critical thinking is different from creative thinking. Creative thinking is the ability to generate new, innovative ideas. Critical thinking requires the candidate to seek information by asking questions, carefully and logically analyze facts, and form a judgment.

Critical Thinking Is Fundamentally a Process of Questioning

A key insight from the research for our book *Decisions Over Decimals*, based on surveying and teaching thousands of executives, is that the smartest person in the room is not the one with the answer but the person asking the question. They are curious, engaged, unafraid, inquisitive, and ready to explore a new domain that may not have answers yet. By the nature of their questions, they demonstrate observation, analysis, inference, interrogation, interpretation, and explanation. Critical thinkers are curious. Innate curiosity has been shown to be associated with the following eight traits—avid learners, problem

solvers, active listeners, self-driven, high productivity, growth mindset, overachievers, and strong at stakeholder management. These traits read like a wish list of qualifications for people you want to be part of your team.

Consulting firms and technology companies have pushed the standard battery of interview questions by using scenario-based or behavioral questions: *How much should you charge to mow a lawn in Atlanta? Why are utility holes round? How would you design a wine rack for people who are blind? If you received \$5 million to solve a global problem, what issue would you address and how?*

These are a good step forward, but while answers to these questions will give you a good idea of candidates' problem-solving skills, ability to deal with ambiguity, and creative thinking, they will not indicate if the candidates are curious, self-starters, or passionate about your company, products, culture, or any of the eight traits referenced earlier.

How do you identify individuals with this versatile and compelling mix of critical thinking and curiosity? Boldly *flip the interview process*.

The oldest and still the most powerful tactic for fostering critical thinking is the Socratic method, developed over 2,400 years ago by the Greek philosopher Socrates. The Socratic method uses thought-provoking question-and-answer probing to promote learning. It focuses on generating more questions than answers, where the answers are not a stopping point but the beginning of further analysis. Hiring managers can apply this model to create a different dialogue with candidates in a modern organization.

The Flip Interview

Let the candidate interview you. The flip interview is an alternate method to uncover a candidate's intrinsic strengths, preferred ways of working, and how they think. The interview will showcase the candidate's thinking and decision-making process and indicate if the candidate exhibits leadership traits.

The flip interview goes beyond letting the candidate ask you open-ended questions like, "What is the company culture?" or "What is it like to work for the company?" The interviewer comes to the discussion with a business scenario, an understanding of relevant information, and an invitation to the interviewee to guide discovery through a series of questions.

The interviewee may use four types of questions, listed below by increasing level of complexity and involvement.

- **Factual questions:** Questions that have straightforward answers based on facts or awareness.
- **Convergent questions:** Close-ended questions with finite answers. Typically, these questions have one correct answer.
- **Divergent questions:** Open-ended questions that encourage many answers. These questions are a means for analyzing a situation, problem, or complexity in greater detail and stimulate creative thought.
- **Evaluative questions:** Questions that require deeper levels of thinking. They can be open or closed. Evaluative questions elicit analysis at multiple levels and from different perspectives to arrive at newly synthesized information or conclusions.

Conducting the Flip Interview: A Four-Step Process

Use the following framework to maximize the value of your conversations with recruits:

1. *Frame*

Briefly describe a scenario. State up front that you are the source of information for the scenario and ask the interviewee to drive the next eight to 12 minutes with a straightforward “How would you start this discovery?” When they inevitably get stuck, prompt them with a branch of the decision tree that opens the discovery further. Invite them to ask questions.

Interviewer evaluation:

In the framing step, you evaluate how they frame the problem. Do they take the situation at face value or probe to get at the essence of the situation? The quality of the questions they ask should lead to determining the information they need, the effort required, and uncover the essential decision to be made. This first step is all about problem-finding more than problem-solving.

2. *Link*

Once they define the problem, invite them to ask questions about context: “Given how you framed the scenario, what other information would you like to know to work toward a recommendation?”

Interviewer evaluation:

You are looking to see if their questions lead them to put the scenario in context. Understanding the context is crucial. To truly put a situation in context, their questions should enable them to triangulate it by looking at it in (1) absolute terms, (2) over time, and (3) relative to what’s going on across the market, with customers or actions from competitors.

3. *Interrogate*

Based on the original scenario, combined with what they learned, ask, “What is the essential decision that is needed?” or “How has their understanding of the situation shifted?”

Interviewer evaluation:

Have they interrogated the situation properly? Are they able to start to formulate the narrative? You are assessing if their narrative is a summary or a synthesis: *summary* is statement of the data; *synthesis* is data plus judgment. The critical thinker will demonstrate how they can consume and synthesize different pieces of information in parallel to arrive at a deeper understanding of the scenario or decision needed.

4. *Perform*

In this final step, ask, “What are the immediate next steps you would take?”

Interviewer evaluation:

If they start to ask questions about key stakeholders, shadow influencers, advocates, or swing voters who need to be convinced, the candidate is thinking critically. Do they seek to learn about headwinds and tailwinds to enable them to move forward? Note: This is not about solving the problem or assessing if they develop a recommendation, but simply how they approach problem-solving and decisions.

Using a flip interview, you can evaluate the candidate’s logic and passion for the role based on their questions. Are the questions superfluous or consequential? Are the questions generic or specific? Do they ask not only factual or convergent but also divergent and evaluative questions? Does the candidate pivot, dive deep, and revisit a topic from different angles? Are the questions grounded in the context of the problem and its environment? As they ask you questions, it will enable you to determine if they are actively listening by adjusting their questions in real-time, pivoting, and probing.

A skilled questioner creates a cooperative dialogue to elicit new learning through a series of questions. They engage the other person. Their questions should lead to inferences and connections and open up viewpoints that are not apparent. This exploration mindset encourages trial and iteration; unexpected learning may originate from the discussion.

Successful candidates in the flip interview will demonstrate a critical thinking mindset. This is different from knowing analytic tools and methods. A critical thinking philosophy is a skill that almost every leader seeks, and many teams have only in short supply. Thinking analytically and critically includes being clear about the purpose of the essential question rather than wandering in the forest of data, being inquisitive not from a statistical perspective but questioning the initial face value, being able to connect the dots via synthesis, and eventually being able to tell an informed story that is based on deeper truths, judgment, and context, not just restating the initial facts.

Reactivity, insight, and ingenuity are needed for companies to thrive. You seek agile thinkers who can be growth champions, truth-tellers, customer stewards, and insight creators. The candidate who can conceptualize the problem, frame the situation, and ask more thoughtful questions will outperform those relying on textbook answers. Hiring talent capable of asking thoughtful questions is the key to building successful teams.

Finally, once you successfully recruit amazing people, you must create an environment where employees are motivated to work collectively yet feel valued and recognized for being curious and inquisitive. An entire organization with a growth mindset that embraces questions and curiosity can reframe challenges as opportunities and move more freely to adjust to business conditions.

Case Study: Microsoft Changes the Interview Process

While their interview was not labeled as a flip interview, a candidate applied for a job at Microsoft in 1998 and found himself in one. During the interview, the recruiter prompted: “Sell me a toaster.” The candidate paused. Then they started to ask questions: “How many people are in the family?” “Are there young children in the house?” “What is the age range of toaster users in the family?” “Do they live in a small space, such as an apartment, or a large house?” “Are they big breakfast eaters, or is their main meal dinner?” “How often do they eat out?” For three minutes, it was a stream of questions about demographics, psychographics, and physical space. The recruiter asked the candidate to stop and asked what this had to do with selling a toaster. The candidate replied, “Everything.”

It is important to discover and understand the context of the “toaster environment” to ensure I sell you what you need. If I match the toaster features and functions to your needs, the success of the sales increases, and you will be a satisfied customer. Do you need a toaster oven, a pop-up two-slice toaster, a four-slice, a wide-slice toaster, a conveyor toaster, a commercial toaster, or a convection oven? Maybe a panini press would serve your needs best.

The exercise was not about the toaster: The recruiter was looking to see how the candidate handled ambiguity. Were they a critical thinker? Did they dive right in with a sales pitch or pause, learn, and pivot? In case you are wondering, the candidate got the job.

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Adapted from “How to Evaluate a Job Candidate’s Critical Thinking Skills in an Interview” on hbr.org, September 25, 2023 (product #H07T10).

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CHAPTER 11

What to Do When You Don't Click with a Candidate

by Rae Ringel

You're 10 minutes into an interview, and it's not going well. The candidate's answers are fine, but they're not sparking your interest. You have at least 35 more minutes allotted together. Don't write them off or muddle through wasting everyone's time by continuing on this path. You have more power than you think to bring life back to a lackluster interview.

It's often easier for hiring managers to connect with candidates who have similar backgrounds, pedigrees, credentials, or perspectives. In fact, research shows that implicit bias shapes interviewers' perceptions of candidates in profound ways.¹ At the same time, research also attests to the enormous benefits of diversity.² As organizations experiment with new ways to attract and retain underrepresented talent, the job interview dynamic merits further attention.

Fortunately, there are proven strategies for boosting your chances of clicking with an interviewee, no matter how or whether your backgrounds align. Here are some steps to breathe new life into interviews that appear to be at their last gasp.

Move your questions into a different domain

If your questions about a candidate's experience and credentials are being met with stilted or incomplete answers, move into a different domain. Instead of focusing on the past, turn to the future: Where do they see themselves three years from now? How will your organization look, feel, and function differently if they're brought on board? Or venture into the realm of magic wands and hypotheticals: "If you were starting a company tomorrow, what would its top three values be?"

If a conversation about tasks, capabilities, and responsibilities is going nowhere, try pivoting toward interpersonal dynamics, which are key to getting things done in any workplace. This area showcases candidates' emotional intelligence. Conversation starters might include: "Tell me about a workplace conflict you were involved in—how did you manage it?" or "What was a moment of pride you experienced recently?" or "How do you respond when a manager criticizes your work?"

Give them control

Typically, interviews end with a standard question: "Is there anything you'd like to ask me?" This, of course, isn't really an invitation to pose the burning questions that are *really* on a candidate's mind—like "When can I expect to be promoted?" or "Is this actually a great place to work, or is all the talk about culture and work-life balance just lip service?" More often, it's code for, "Here's your chance to dazzle me with a question that makes you look smart and shows that you've done your homework on us."

If an interview is lacking chemistry, consider handing the reins over earlier in the conversation, with an invitation that's more genuine. Perhaps ask the candidate, "What should I be asking you?" or "What question do you wish I had asked?" Being the interviewee can feel powerless. Questions like this disrupt that dynamic and allow the candidate to set the agenda.

Give them a challenge

Some people are uncomfortable talking about themselves for reasons that may stem from personality, culture, or neurodivergence. When they're aware that this is an issue for them, it can compound the problem. They may retreat further inward as their self-consciousness spirals, or they may overcompensate by name-dropping or raising their volume. If you suspect this might be the root of the disconnect, try shifting the focus from the person to the work.

One strategy is to fill the candidate in on a challenge that the team they'd be joining is currently struggling with, and ask what suggestions they have for tackling it. Since the problem is active and ongoing, there's no pressure to come up with the "right" answer. Instead, you'll get a glimpse into how the person thinks, their willingness to explore angles from all sides, the questions they ask, and the creativity they bring. Collaborative problem-solving skills are in high demand, and this can be an opportunity to assess them in action.

Steer them toward career development

Today's candidates prize career development.³ If your organization is investing in this area, describe some of your career development options to the candidate and ask which ones excite them the most. You can learn a lot about someone by seeing how they approach learning itself. What skills and capabilities are they most eager to cultivate? Are there other offerings they'd like to see on your career development menu?

Career development benefits individuals as well as the organization. When you bring in employees who are invested in learning and growing, their current skill sets are less important than the certainty that they'll evolve alongside the business.

Get curious

Leaders often rise based on their ability to make quick judgments. When it comes to interviewing job candidates, this can be a liability. If you're not connecting with a candidate, resist the temptation to cut things short or check out mentally. Instead, go in the opposite direction. Embrace your curiosity.

You might start by getting curious about why the conversation isn't flowing or the cadence doesn't feel right. Challenge yourself to consider what might be at play: Might the candidate be distracted because they're wearing jeans while you're in a suit, or the other way around? Could this be their first in-person interview after years of remote work—or their first time being assessed remotely? What would happen if you paused for a longer period of time after posing each question, inviting the candidate to take their time answering?

If you're struggling to muster genuine curiosity, double down on *conveying* that you're interested and engaged. Open-ended questions like "What inspires you?" or "What's something that you find interesting but others might find boring?" often elicit new energy, sparking interest that's authentic.

Set the stage for success

There are certain stage-setters that can improve your chances of connecting with an interviewee. If you know you have a tendency to connect more fluidly with people of a certain gender, ethnicity, or educational background, make a quick list of these "affinity biases" so you're more fully aware of your need to work against them.

Give yourself and the candidate time to prepare by making all necessary materials (including topics of discussion or assignments) available ahead of the interview. Slow thinkers can be the deepest thinkers, and this gives them time to gather their thoughts and make their best case.

If you're conducting a remote interview, consider letting candidates choose between a videoconference or phone call. People's home office and technology setups may vary, and it would be a shame if a distracting Zoom background or spotty connection kept you from identifying the best person for the job.

Above all, it's important to remember that recruiters and hiring managers are not just gatekeepers, but ambassadors for their organizations. If you're not clicking with a candidate, chances are they're also not clicking with you.

By working thoughtfully and strategically to move the conversation in a different direction, you'll raise your chances of leaving candidates with a positive impression. At the very least, they'll have good things to say about their candidate experience. And you may just discover an overlooked gem who'd be absolutely perfect for your team.

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Adapted from "How to Interview a Candidate You Don't Immediately Click With" on hbr.org, March 4, 2024 (product #H081MJ).

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CHAPTER 12

Make Interviews More Accessible

by Rebecca Knight

Designing an accessible, inclusive interview process for disabled people and people with different learning styles both widens the talent pool and creates a more equitable workplace.

For hiring managers, this requires a thoughtful and conscientious approach. Where do you begin? What actions can you take to accommodate candidates' needs? How do you maintain consistent evaluation criteria? And how can you set up an environment where all candidates have opportunities to demonstrate their strengths?

What the Experts Say

Disability, as defined by the International Classification of Impairments, Disabilities and Handicaps, refers to “any restriction or lack (resulting from an impairment) of ability to perform an activity in the manner or within the range considered normal for a human being.”¹ A record share of disabled people were employed in the United States last year, according to a report from the Bureau of Labor Statistics.² This is progress but more can be done, according to Katie Bach, a former nonresident senior fellow at the Brookings Institution who has spent most of her career focused on job creation, access, and quality.

It starts with creating a level playing field in job interviews. “Offering accommodations to candidates is table stakes,” she says. “What I see as the next step is not just asking individuals if they need accommodation, but helping candidates think through what kinds of accommodations might be possible.”

Reimagining old, outmoded interview tactics is also key, says Ludmila Praslova, professor of organizational psychology at Vanguard University and the author of *The Canary Code: A Guide to Neurodiversity, Dignity, and Intersectional Belonging at Work*.³ “We’ve been using the same methods for years without considering what’s truly needed for a specific job and how to identify the right candidate,” she says. After all, the goal of job interviews is to uncover a candidate’s potential and “assess whether that individual has the necessary skills for the role; everything else creates unnecessary barriers.”

Here are some strategies for making your job interviews fairer and more inclusive.

Increase your understanding of disability

First things first: You need to break free from your preconceived ideas about disability, says Bach. “Many of us hold a certain image of what disability looks like and assume that we haven’t worked with many disabled people.”

But statistically speaking, this belief is unlikely to reflect reality. Roughly one in four Americans lives with a disability, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, and studies suggest that about 9% of Americans have a learning difference.⁴ Many of these differences and disabilities are hidden or invisible.

Meanwhile, 61% of disabled workers have experienced bias, mistreatment, and bullying on the job, research shows.⁵ “Once you broaden your understanding of disability and its implications,” says Bach, “you realize it’s far more prevalent and complex than you thought.”

Which is all to say that when it comes to designing more inclusive, accessible job interviews, “sometimes you need to open yourself up to less comfortable forms of understanding,” notes Praslova. “That means listening without judgment and not making assumptions about someone faking or being lazy or high-maintenance.”

Recognize that people may need accommodations and that strict conformity to traditional interview methods can perpetuate bias. Empathy is important—but even empathy has its limitations, Praslova observes: “It’s not about you, it’s about the other person. And their reality might be very different from yours.”

Look critically at your current practices

Next, examine your current interview practices and techniques and identify unnecessary hurdles that don’t reflect actual job requirements.

“Sometimes interviews are designed to trick people, make them emotional, and throw them off balance to see how they perform under pressure,” says Praslova. But these tactics could disproportionately disadvantage candidates with social anxiety or neurodivergent thinking, and thus pose greater challenges in these situations. “You’re not interviewing for the Secret Service,” she says.

Bach agrees. The interview doesn’t have to perfectly mimic the conditions of the job, but you might want to examine any “physically and psychologically demanding practices” and perhaps make adjustments, she says. (More on this later.) Do interviews need to be all-day marathons? Must they include 90-minute-long, on-the-fly case studies? Do they even need to be in person? “If it’s not part of the job, you need to ask yourself: ‘Are we creating an environment that anyone can thrive in? Or are we making it artificially hard?’”

Ask candidates what they need

Unfortunately, there isn’t a one-size-fits-all solution for making interviews more inclusive, says Bach. “Even people with the same disability can have different symptoms and severities,” which is why you need to work with individual candidates to determine what they might need.

Bach suggests creating “a menu of possible accommodations” that includes examples of what’s been done in the past. This might include providing extra time for completing tasks or responding to interview questions, presenting questions in different formats to address different learning styles, or conducting remote interviews for candidates who may have mobility challenges.

Praslova recommends sharing this menu of options with all candidates and encouraging them to request additional support if needed. “Make it clear that it’s safe to ask for things and it won’t be held against them,” she says, noting research that suggests disclosing a disability at work is often a fraught experience.⁶ Praslova champions the “platinum rule”—an evolved version of the golden rule: “Treat others as they want to be treated,” she says. “It’s not what *you* want, it’s what the *other person* wants.”

Build in flexibility and humanity

In addition to offering specific accommodations, Praslova suggests building flexibility, convenience, and humanity into your interviews. “If you create environments that are good for canaries, they’ll be good for everyone,” she says. For example, she recommends conducting interviews in quiet, private spaces to reduce distractions and sensory overload; limiting the number of interviews a candidate must attend in one day; and providing personalized support.

“If you’re inviting people to a physical site, meet them at the door and guide them to the interview,” she says. “If it’s a virtual interview, don’t assume [they’re familiar and comfortable with the platform your company prefers]. Even when things feel obvious to you, try to put yourself in the candidate’s shoes.”

Praslova also recommends providing all candidates with interview questions in advance. Not only does this allow them time to prepare thoughtful responses, it also removes some of the psychological stress associated with interviews. Otherwise, she says, you may unintentionally place a higher value on their confidence, rather than their skills and abilities. “When you’re measuring people’s quickness on their feet, sometimes what you’re getting is their overconfidence.”

Use structured interviews

While open-ended, more casual interviews have their appeal, research shows that structured interviews—which involve a set number of predetermined questions—are less biased and tend to offer a more accurate assessment of a candidate’s suitability for a role.⁷ “A lot of interviews basically come down to some variation of the airport test: Does this person vibe with me?” says Praslova. Structured interviews, on the other hand, “have checklists and processes that scaffold hiring managers into fairness.”

To ensure fairness and objectivity, evaluate candidates solely on these established criteria and support your assessment with solid evidence. Don’t let factors like what the candidate is wearing, how nervous they appear, or how easily they engage in small talk influence the interview, she adds. “Know what you’re assessing and only assess that,” she says. “Candidates want you to focus on their strengths and abilities and what they can do.”

This article follows the preference of autistic and disabled communities for identity-first language.

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Adapted from “How to Make Job Interviews More Accessible” on hbr.org, June 7, 2024 (product #H088YP).

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CHAPTER 13

How to Answer an Open-Ended Question from a Candidate

by Marlo Lyons

While interviewers often assume they hold all the power during the interview process, candidates are increasingly asking more insightful questions to assess whether they should make a move to a new company. Just as candidates prepare for interviews, interviewers need to put some thought into likely topics of conversation to be ready to answer open-ended questions from candidates—because your responses could either ignite their enthusiasm or dampen their interest in the opportunity.

Here are five strategies you can use to prepare for and address open-ended questions from candidates, with the goal of enticing them to eagerly pursue an open position with your company.

Know what information is confidential

Interviewers play a critical role in preserving confidentiality during the interview process, recognizing the sensitive nature of certain information that cannot be disclosed to candidates, even if they've signed a nondisclosure agreement (NDA). Understanding the boundaries of confidentiality is essential, as it protects proprietary information, trade secrets, and other sensitive data integral to the company's operations.

While NDAs offer legal protection, it's imperative for interviewers to exercise discretion and refrain from sharing confidential details such as upcoming product launches, strategic plans, or proprietary technologies during interviews. However, withholding information or stumbling while answering a question may project a lack of transparency within the company, which could turn off a candidate from wanting to work there. If you're unsure what information is confidential, discuss in advance with your manager or the legal department so you can confidently speak about confidential matters in a way that safeguards the company's interests while conveying enough information to satisfy the candidate.

If you're unable to share information, simply say, "I am so glad you asked that question. It gives me an understanding of how you think about the company. Unfortunately, I can't answer it because [e.g., of regulatory matters; of SEC disclosures; it's not public yet; I don't know the answer, but I will follow up with you]." Acknowledging the question will prevent a candidate from feeling like you're brushing them off or evading the question.

Prepare for common questions

Candidates often ask about company culture; for example, "Can you tell me about the culture?" or "What about the culture drew you to the company?" or "How has the culture changed over the last five years?" Instead of simply stating a preference for the culture or highlighting collaborative dynamics, it's essential to offer tangible examples or scenarios. The aim is to answer the question in a way that will

give the candidate a good sense of how their working style would fit in and help them feel at ease about the prospect of joining the team, fostering a sense of comfort and belonging.

For example, you could talk about that time your cross-functional colleagues rallied to support you during a challenging project, displaying the organization's collaborative spirit. Or you could share a personal experience that illustrates the company's encouragement of work-life balance, such as how you're able to pick up your children every day at 3 p.m. or how you approach unplugging during vacations (and how you empower team members to do the same). And despite the passage of time since the Covid-19 lockdown, it's still valuable to describe how the company supported employees during that period, shedding light on its commitment to employee well-being and resilience.

The best reply to a question about culture always includes an example and the impact. For instance, "When we say our culture is built around 'One Team,' we mean it. That's what helps us maintain trust and ensure collaboration above personal interest. Just last week, our team was struggling to complete a major project. We alerted the broader team including cross-functional stakeholders. Everyone came together—including team members from other departments—to ensure we met our goal. Our goal is their goal. Their goal is our goal. That is how we view our work."

Another common question is about how the position came to be available. For example, "What is the history of this position?" or "What happened to the last person in this position?" The candidate is asking about whether the role is newly created or is vacant due to a departure or internal transfer. Transparency regarding the position's background, including its origins and any notable achievements or areas for improvement due to shifting needs, can give candidates valuable insight into role expectations. Additionally, discussing how the company decided to create a new role, the significance of the position, and how the person in the position will interact cross-functionally can help candidates better understand how their past experiences align with the job requirements.

Your answer should be short, clear, and if possible, related to the candidate. "This is a new position that we realized we needed to accelerate the business. Your skill set is exactly what we need." Or "This is a replacement position. The last person was promoted into a new role and is still at the company so he would be available for questions and onboarding to ensure your success." If the last person to hold the position left the company or was fired, consider saying something along the lines of "The last person held the position for three years and decided to depart the company for a new opportunity. We revised the position based on the current team needs. That's why I'm talking to you, because your skill set is right on point."

Connect answers to each candidate's skills and experience

Just as candidates strive to establish a connection during interviews, interviewers must do the same. When candidates ask questions about the position, relate your responses directly to their experience, citing specific examples from their résumé or interview answers.

For example, if the candidate asks how you'll measure success, draw parallels between their past achievements and the role's requirements. Maybe they previously gave you an example of how they created and led a specific marketing campaign targeting a diverse audience; you could answer their question by connecting their example to a role requirement of growing your product's reach to specific demographics and the corresponding key performance indicators for success.

For example, a candidate may ask, "What is the intangible thing you're looking for that's not on the job description?" Tailor your answer to align with information the candidate has already mentioned, such as "One of the main intangibles is someone who has innovated from white space, such as the creator of the first cell phone or digital watch. The story you told about how you were the innovator behind [unique technology] and how you used data to align the senior leadership toward pursuing it, is exactly the kind of visionary leadership we are looking for in this role."

Tying your answers directly to the candidate's skills and experience not only strengthens your connection, it also fosters a more meaningful and productive interview experience for each of you.

Highlight growth opportunities

As interviewers evaluate a candidate's potential fit within the company and team, candidates likewise assess whether their skills will be valued, if growth opportunities exist, and how their past experiences align with the company's goals.

Listen attentively during the interview to discern each candidate's short- and long-term aspirations. This will help you determine which company programs to highlight, from personalized coaching to educational courses to industry conferences. Discuss success stories of employees who have capitalized on the company's resources and growth opportunities, resulting in promotions or transitions to new roles that allow them to utilize their newly acquired skills. Be prepared to talk about how experience gained in the role could lead to particular career trajectories, as well as mentorship initiatives, training programs, and prospective projects that could help the candidate attain their career goals within the company, even if it means transitioning to a different department in the future.

For example, you could say something along the lines of "One of my risk analyst employees took advantage of our tuition reimbursement program to complete an MBA with a concentration in data science. I helped her find a mentor with one of our senior data scientists, which led to a stretch assignment with our data science team. The skills she acquired and the networking she did while working on that assignment positioned her to secure the next open data science position with the team. While it was sad to see her move onto a new team, I am proud of how hard she worked to reach her goals and I know she will bring even more value to the company. This is the kind of growth we actively support and encourage here, because we want high performers to know that they have a pathway for career advancement that is tailored to their individual aspirations."

Demonstrate self-awareness

Just as interviewers aim to select a candidate who will thrive within the company, candidates want assurance that they'll enjoy working for the hiring manager if they get the job. Candidates who are trying to understand whether the manager's leadership style will work for them may ask questions such as, "Can you tell me about a time when you feel like you failed an employee?" or "How do you view your job in support of this role?" or "What is one quality in your leadership style that you expect your leaders to emulate?" You can seize the opportunity presented by these open-ended questions to candidly discuss your past mistakes, areas for improvement, and leadership approach, displaying vulnerability and fostering a sense of psychological safety for the candidate.

For example, you could demonstrate self-awareness in your response by saying something such as "I once failed an employee when I didn't provide enough guidance on a major project. I assumed they had everything under control and I didn't want to micromanage them, so I didn't dive into the details, and they missed a key deadline. Since then, I've made it a priority to have regular check-ins on major projects to ensure that my team feels comfortable asking for help or telling me when they're overwhelmed. I view my job as providing the resources and support my team needs to succeed. I expect my leaders to foster an environment where open communication and continuous improvement are encouraged. I learned a lot from this experience, specifically how to stay engaged and accessible while also empowering my team to own their work."

Interviewers should prepare for interviews just as thoroughly as candidates do. Being equipped with compelling stories and setting aside dedicated preparation time (for example, 30 minutes beforehand) allows interviewers to mentally prepare and be fully present during the interview. As with candidates, it's not only the content of what is said that matters, but also the manner in which it's conveyed. Demonstrating enthusiasm for the company and the position can leave a lasting impression on candidates, instilling confidence and enthusiasm in their decision-making process.

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CHAPTER 14

Should You Use AI to Assess Candidates?

by Tomas Chamorro-Premuzic and Reece Akhtar

Few things seem creepier than algorithms mining our voices, résumés, or photos to determine whether we should be considered for a job, and yet this is now the reality for most job seekers.¹ What's more, it may not be as creepy as you think.

For starters, all organizations struggle with talent identification, which is why many complain that they are unable to find the right person for key positions and why most people end up in jobs that are far from inspiring.² Consider that even in the biggest economy in the world, where talent management practices are far more science-driven and sophisticated than anywhere else, the labor market is quite inefficient.

Today in the United States, there are around six million job seekers for eight million job openings.³ Even if we look at the global knowledge economy, comprised of the most qualified and skilled cognitive elite (roughly the one billion people who are on LinkedIn), job satisfaction is the exception rather than the norm: It is estimated that as many as 70% of these top talented individuals are open to other, hopefully more meaningful or interesting, jobs or careers.⁴ Elsewhere, the norm characterizing recruitment and hiring processes is considerably more backward, with hiring managers overemphasizing hard skills at the expense of the more important and critical soft skills or using intuitive yet biased hiring methods, such as the unstructured job interview, to determine who gets the job.⁵ All the while, predictive assessments and data-driven tools are largely underutilized, and the prevalence of prejudice, bias, and discrimination is everywhere.⁶

In short, if we want to make talent identification more effective—and more meritocratic—it's important to continue to look beyond existing methods, particularly if recent technological innovations such as advances in machine-learning and generative artificial intelligence enable us to predict, understand, and match people at scale.

One of the major problems with the way we currently interview job candidates is that the process is largely unstructured, leaving the questioning to the whims and fancies of the interviewer. It shouldn't take much convincing to see how this is not only inefficient, but also leads to biased decision-making as interviewers express and seek to confirm their own preferences.⁷

Video or digital interviews can remove these limitations almost entirely. Using generative AI to create a highly structured and standardized interview experience, every candidate can be presented with the same set questions and be given the same opportunity to express their talent, which ultimately improves the video's predictive utility.⁸

But while digital interviews provide a fairer interview experience for candidates and allow organizations to access more diverse talent, when it comes to reviewing these interviews, we run into the same problems—biased humans are left to make the hiring decisions. But what if AI and machine-

learning algorithms were tasked with mining the data from these videos to identify reliable connections between what people do and say during interviews, and their personality, ability, or job performance? In the case of digital interviews, AI algorithms can mine a candidate's facial expressions and body language, along with what they say and how they say it.⁹

Mining all this data can reveal a lot about the candidate's talent and can indicate how they might perform on the job. Scientific research in this area has been steadily growing, revealing interesting and promising findings.¹⁰ For instance, researchers have trained algorithms that mine various characteristics of an individual's voice (e.g., vocal pitch, loudness, and intensity); body movement (e.g., hand gestures, posture, etc.); or facial expressions (e.g., happiness, surprise, anger) to accurately predict their personality profile, which we know is one of the leading predictors of job performance.¹¹

Going further, researchers have mined similar signals to predict behaviors and qualities that are critical for performance: communication skills, persuasiveness, stress tolerance, and leadership.¹² Further revealing how insightful this technology truly is, a team of researchers used the aforementioned technologies to quantify the emotionality of CEOs as they spoke in conference calls to accurately predict the firm's future financial performance.¹³

AI has the potential to significantly improve the way we identify talent because it can reduce the cost of making accurate predictions about a candidate's potential while at the same time removing the bias and heuristics that so often cloud human judgment. The fact that AI algorithms can detect and measure latent or seemingly intangible human qualities may lead some to be skeptical of the findings discussed here, but it is worth noting that there are plenty of scientific studies that demonstrate that humans can accurately identify personality and intellect from just thin slices of verbal and nonverbal behavior.¹⁴ AI algorithms simply leverage the same cues. The difference between humans and AI is that the latter can scale and can be automated. What's more, AI does not have an ego that needs to be managed.

Currently, many organizations that use digital interviews do not leverage these types of powerful AI analytics, as their recruiters are often unwilling to accept the algorithm's recommendations and continue to rely on their own naive judgement. Sadly, this behavior is harming both the candidate and the organization. The HR departments that realize that science and data, and not intuition or instinct, should be the basis for decisions will attract and retain the best talent. Of course, we do not advocate that all hiring decisions be made by an AI system. There must always be human oversight. Instead, we believe that human decisions can be significantly improved if there is accurate and valid data to inform and shape our judgments. For example, AI-enabled digital interviews can be used to analyze candidates' soft skills, technical competence, facial expressions, vocal tones, and body language. These insights can then be integrated into a comprehensive candidate profile, offering hiring managers a detailed and objective evaluation. This approach not only enhances the predictive validity of the hiring process but also reduces biases, leading to more equitable and effective hiring decisions. Importantly, it's also crucial to design these AI tools with user experience in mind to ensure a fair and transparent process that respects and engages candidates.

Of course, it's essential to consider the legal and ethical implications of using these innovative tech tools, just as we do when we consider using traditional assessment methods.¹⁵ AI systems can end up learning all sorts of harmful biases of their own, depending on the data they're trained on, among other factors. There are new regulations from New York, California, and the European Union placing pressure on companies to pay attention to how these systems are trained, and also regularly audit them for potential bias.¹⁶ Also, clearly, there is now a difference between what we *can* know about people, and what we *should* know about them, with the possibilities surpassing both legal and ethical boundaries.

Yet at the same time, it's still possible to deploy innovations like the ones we describe here while operating within the constraints of good codes of conduct. Candidates can be fully briefed and debriefed about the technologies being used to evaluate them, and should be invited to actively opt in. Organizations should fully protect and keep safe all sensitive data, and the entire process should be

transparent. In fact, it is even possible (and advisable) for candidates to have ownership of their data and results, which they may voluntarily decide to share with selected recruiters and employers—or not. While this scenario may seem more utopian than the emerging technologies we described, we would like to urge recruiters and employers to consider it. After all, there is no tension between understanding job candidates well and helping them understand themselves better. Organizations—and individuals—will benefit enormously when new technologies can boost their ability to place the right person in the right job.

THREE STRATEGIES TO MATCH THE RIGHT TOOLS TO THE RIGHT PROCESSES

Making great hiring decisions is the result of matching the right tools with the right processes. Practice these three strategies to increase your chances of finding and recruiting the very best talent:

1. **Adopt structured and standardized practices:** To ensure a fair and consistent hiring process, organizations should adopt structured and standardized evaluation methods. By using a set of predetermined questions and criteria for all candidates, and implementing hiring scorecards, recruiters and hiring managers can objectively assess responses, minimizing the influence of personal biases. Structured interviews not only enhance the reliability of the hiring process but also provide a clear framework for comparing candidates on an equal footing.
2. **Leverage predictive assessments and analytics:** Incorporating scientifically-validated assessments and AI-driven tools can significantly enhance the accuracy of hiring decisions. Predictive assessments, such as cognitive ability tests and personality assessments, offer valuable insights into a candidate's potential beyond their résumé. AI and data analytics can further refine this process by analyzing video interviews for non-verbal cues, providing objective insights into a candidate's soft skills. These technologies help in identifying patterns and predicting success, thereby making the hiring process more data-driven and less reliant on subjective judgment.
3. **Focus on continuous training to mitigate bias:** Continuous training is crucial to keep hiring managers updated on the latest recruitment technologies and best practices. Regular workshops, webinars, and industry conferences can provide the necessary skills to use new tools effectively. Moreover, it's essential to provide bias training and conduct regular audits of hiring practices. This ensures that both human and AI decision-makers are free from prejudices, promoting a more inclusive and equitable hiring process. Ensuring that AI tools are trained on diverse datasets and regularly audited for potential biases is also critical.

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